

Day 4 — The Four Upavedas

Module: What is IKS? (Middle) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students name the four Upavedas and one specific contribution of each.

Materials

- Whiteboard
- Visual cards or images (a surgical instrument, a vīṇā, a martial pose, a manuscript)

Vocabulary

- *Upaveda* — “subordinate Veda”; applied sciences
- *cikitsā* — “treatment, therapy”

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Daily prompt + recall: name 3 of the 6 Vedāṅgas.

Core (20 min)

1. The Four Upavedas — the APPLIED sciences:

#	Sanskrit	Domain	Primary text
1	<i>Āyurveda</i>	Medicine	Caraka Saṃhitā (~2nd c. BCE), Suśruta Saṃhitā
2	<i>Dhanurveda</i>	Martial arts & warfare	Various manuals; partial extant
3	<i>Gandharvaveda</i>	Music	Bharata’s <i>Nāṭyaśāstra</i> (~2nd c. BCE)
4	<i>Arthaśāstra</i>	Governance & economics	Kauṭilya’s <i>Arthaśāstra</i> (~3rd c. BCE)

(Note: classifications vary. *Sthāpatya-veda* — architecture — sometimes counted as a 5th. Stick to the standard 4 for clarity.)

2. Tour each briefly:

Āyurveda — *Caraka Saṃhitā* lays out a full theory of health, the three doshas (vāta, pitta, kapha), diagnostic methods, and pharmacology. Module 3 covers this in depth.

Dhanurveda — From *dhanus* (bow). Military training, weapon usage, fortification. Many texts lost; what survives is referenced in epics and later manuals.

Gandharvaveda — Music and performing arts. Bharata’s *Nāṭyaśāstra* covers theatre, music, dance — the foundational text for Indian classical performing arts.

Arthaśāstra — Kauṭilya (a.k.a. Cāṇakya) wrote a treatise on statecraft, economics, and governance. Compared sometimes to Machiavelli’s *Prince*, but ~1800 years older and more systematic.

3. A specific Upaveda achievement to remember:

- **Suśruta’s surgery** (~6th c. BCE or earlier): the *Suśruta Saṃhitā* describes 300+ surgical procedures including cataract surgery and rhinoplasty (plastic surgery on the nose). The “Sushruta nose” reconstruction technique was learned by European surgeons via translation in the 18th century.

Activity (15 min) — Match an Upaveda to a problem

Teacher gives 5 modern problems on the board. Students decide which Upaveda’s tradition would have addressed each:

1. “I have a chronic skin issue, what would the tradition suggest?” (Āyurveda)
2. “Our city needs a new defence strategy” (Dhanurveda + Arthaśāstra)
3. “How should taxes be calculated for the rainy season?” (Arthaśāstra)
4. “I want to learn a new rāga on the vīṇā” (Gandharvaveda)
5. “Our king wants to build a court of judges” (Arthaśāstra)

Discuss: where would Suśruta have fit? (Āyurveda — surgery is a subdomain of medicine in this scheme.)

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 5: “Tomorrow — mid-module quiz on everything we’ve covered so far.”

Student-facing content

The Four Upavedas — the APPLIED sciences

#	Sanskrit	Domain
1	Āyurveda	Medicine
2	Dhanurveda	Martial arts
3	Gandharvaveda	Music
4	Arthaśāstra	Governance & economics

Standout achievement: **Suśruta’s surgical procedures** (~6th c. BCE), including cataract surgery and nose reconstruction.

Homework

- Look up “Kauṭilya’s Arthaśāstra” online. Find ONE specific governance idea it contains (e.g. spy networks, foreign-policy doctrine, tax classifications). Bring tomorrow.

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read the first chapter of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* in translation. What does it claim is the *origin* of theatre?
- **Tier down:** Memorise just the four Upavedas with one-line domains.

Teacher notes

- The classification of Upavedas is somewhat traditional and not perfectly clean. Some sources include 5 (adding Sthāpatya-veda — architecture). Stick to 4 for clarity; mention the 5th briefly.
- The Sushruta-nose-reconstruction history is genuine; European surgeons did learn the technique via 18th-century Bengali practitioners. It's a documented case of pre-modern Indian medical knowledge influencing modern medicine.

Citation(s) used

- Wujastyk (2003) on Caraka & Suśruta.
- Boesche, R. (2003). *The First Great Political Realist: Kautilya and His Arthashastra*. Lexington.
- Bharata, *Nāṭyaśāstra* — various editions.